The Knowledge Argument

Frank Jackson's Mary and the three responses on the specification

This workbook consolidates what you have covered in the slideshow and handout. Work through it in order, or jump to the part you need. Every task can be done on your own, so if you missed a lesson you can still catch up. Answers to the recall tasks are at the back: try first, then check.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

In this workbook

1. Where am I now? A self-check
2. Key terms
3. Quick recall
4. Argument reconstruction
5. Objections and evaluation
6. Exam practice (3, 5, 12 and 25 marks)
7. Answers

> **Key Thesis**
> Knowing **all the physical facts** about colour vision is not knowing **everything** about it. Mary knows every physical fact but learns something new when she first sees red. So there are non-physical facts, and **physicalism is false** (Frank Jackson, 'Epiphenomenal Qualia', 1982).

Part 01 Where am I now?

How to use this section

Tick a column for each statement **before** you start, then again **when you finish**. Green = I could explain it to someone else. Amber = I half get it. Red = not yet.

I can...	Start	End
tell the Mary story accurately	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
set out the argument in standard form	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
define qualia, propositional knowledge, ability knowledge and acquaintance knowledge	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain Lewis's ability knowledge response	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain the acquaintance knowledge response	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain the new knowledge/old fact response (Tye) with the water/H_2O example	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
reach and defend a judgement on the knowledge argument	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G

Part 02 Key terms

Task 1 · Match the term to its definition

Write the letter of the correct definition next to each term.

Term	Letter
Qualia	
Physicalism	
Propositional knowledge	
Ability knowledge	
Acquaintance knowledge	
Phenomenal concept	
Epiphenomenalism	
New knowledge/old fact	

	Definition
A	Knowing how: e.g. how to remember, imagine and recognise red (Lewis).
B	Mary gains a new concept of a fact she already knew under a physical description.
C	A concept of an experience grasped by having it, e.g. *this* look of red.
D	Everything is physical or supervenes upon the physical.
E	Mental experience is a by-product of the brain with no causal influence on the physical world.
F	Knowing that something is the case: knowledge of facts.
G	Knowing something directly by encountering it, as opposed to knowing about it.
H	The intrinsic phenomenal character of experience, e.g. the way red looks or coffee smells.

Task 2 · Fill the gaps

Use the word bank. Each word is used once.

Key idea Word bank: room · fact · like · physical · Tye · vision · physicalism · ability · ripe · Lewis

Mary is a brilliant scientist who studies the neurophysiology of _____ from a black and white _____. She knows all the _____ information about colour. When she is released and sees a _____ tomato, it seems she learns something new: what it is _____ to see red. Jackson concludes that _____ is false. David _____ replies that Mary only gains _____ knowledge, while Michael _____ argues she gains new knowledge of an old _____.

Task 3 · In your own words

Retell the Mary thought experiment in no more than five sentences, then say in one sentence what Jackson thinks it proves.

Part 03 Quick recall

How to use this section

Answer from memory first. Then check your notes, and add anything you missed in a different colour. That second colour shows you exactly what to revise.

1. Where does Mary live and what does she study?

2. What does Mary know before her release?

3. What does Jackson claim happens on her release?

4. What is the conclusion of the knowledge argument?

5. What does Lewis say Mary gains?

6. What does the acquaintance response say Mary gains?

7. Explain the new knowledge/old fact response using water.

8. Why does Jackson end up defending epiphenomenalism?

Part 04 Argument reconstruction

How to use this section

Each argument below has been jumbled. Number the lines into the right order (premises first, conclusion last). Then answer the questions underneath. Being able to set out an argument in standard form is exactly what the 5-mark and 12-mark questions reward.

Jackson's knowledge argument

Order	Jumbled line
	Therefore, physicalism is false.
	So there are facts about colour vision that are not physical facts.
	Before her release, Mary knows all the physical facts about colour vision.
	Before her release, Mary does not know everything about colour vision (she learns something on release).
	If physicalism is true, all facts are physical facts.

→ Which premise do the ability and acquaintance responses attack? (Hint: they deny Mary learns a new *fact*.)

→ Which step does the new knowledge/old fact response attack?

The new knowledge/old fact response

Order	Jumbled line
	Therefore, the knowledge argument does not show there are non-physical facts.
	One and the same fact can be known under two different concepts (water / H_2O).
	Knowing a fact under one concept does not guarantee knowing it under the other.
	This concept picks out a physical fact she already knew under a physical concept.
	On release, Mary acquires a phenomenal concept of seeing red.

Order	Jumbled line
	So Mary gains new knowledge, but not knowledge of a new fact.

→ Why does your conclusion slide say this shows the argument is about *concepts* rather than what *exists*?

→ How might Jackson reply that the phenomenal concept still needs explaining?

Part 05 Objections and evaluation

How to use this section

For each objection: explain the problem in your own words, write the best response, then judge whether the response works. The hint column is there if you are stuck; cover it up if you want a harder challenge.

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
Ability knowledge (Lewis)	Knowing how vs knowing that.			
Acquaintance knowledge	Knowing London by visiting vs reading about it.			
New knowledge / old fact (Tye)	Water and H_2O: two ideas, one thing.			

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
Could Mary really know everything physical?	We can't imagine *all* physical knowledge.			
Epiphenomenalism follows	If qualia are non-physical and physics is closed...			

Ranking the objections

Which objection is the **most** damaging, and which is the **least**? Justify your choice: a strong objection attacks a key premise and is hard to answer.

Most damaging: _____ because...

Least damaging: _____ because...

Building a judgement

Does the knowledge argument show physicalism is false? Decide which response is strongest and whether it fully defeats Jackson.

Key idea Sentence starters: *The strongest argument for this view is... because...* · *However, this is undermined by...* · *A defender might reply that... but this fails / succeeds because...* · *Therefore, on balance...*

Part 06

Exam practice

How to use this section

On Paper 2 the **3-, 5- and 12-mark** questions test **AO1** only: knowledge and understanding, shown through precise, accurate explanation. The **25-mark** question is **5 marks AO1 + 20 marks AO2**: you must argue, evaluate and reach a judgement that your essay supports throughout.

Spend roughly a minute per mark. Plan before you write.

3 marks · What is meant by 'qualia'?

Key idea AO1 · A precise definition or short point. One or two accurate sentences; no evaluation needed.

5 marks · Explain the knowledge argument for property dualism.

Key idea AO1 · Set out the idea or argument clearly and in logical order. Precise terminology; a standard-form layout often works best.

Planning frame

1. Describe Mary and her room.
2. Premise: she knows all physical facts.
3. Premise: she learns something new on release.
4. Conclude: some facts are non-physical; physicalism is false.

12 marks · Explain the 'ability knowledge' response to the knowledge argument, and how Jackson could reply.

Key idea AO1 · A full, precise explanation. Show how the ideas connect logically, step by step. Do **not** evaluate: explain.

Planning frame

1. State the knowledge argument briefly.
2. Distinguish knowing-that from knowing-how.
3. Explain Lewis: Mary gains abilities to remember, imagine, recognise; no new fact.
4. Explain Jackson's possible reply: she seems to gain a fact too.

25 marks · Does the knowledge argument succeed in showing that physicalism is false?

Key idea AO1 (5) + AO2 (20) · State your line of argument in the introduction and keep to it. Every paragraph should argue, not just describe: point → objection → response → mini-judgement. End with a conclusion that follows from what you have argued.

Model structure

Section	What to do	My plan
Introduction	Define the key terms. State your thesis: the answer you will defend.	
Paragraph 1	The argument and its intuitive force → mini-judgement.	

Section	What to do	My plan
Paragraph 2	The ability knowledge response → reply → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 3	The acquaintance knowledge response → reply → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 4	The new knowledge/old fact response → reply → mini-judgement.	
Conclusion	Restate your judgement and explain **why** the balance of argument supports it. No new arguments.	

Write your essay on lined paper, or continue below.

Reflect

Go back to Part 01 and fill in the **End** column. Which statement is still red or amber? Write one specific thing you will do about it.

Part 07 Answers

How to use this section

Use these to check Parts 02–04. Exam answers are not given here: bring them to your teacher, or mark against the AO guidance.

Task 1 · Matching

Qualia = H · Physicalism = D · Propositional knowledge = F · Ability knowledge = A · Acquaintance knowledge = G · Phenomenal concept = C · Epiphenomenalism = E · New knowledge/old fact = B

Task 2 · Gaps

(1) vision · (2) room · (3) physical · (4) ripe · (5) like · (6) physicalism · (7) Lewis · (8) ability · (9) Tye · (10) fact

Quick recall

1. A black and white room, via a black and white monitor; the neurophysiology of vision.
2. All the physical information there is about colour vision.
3. She learns something new about the world and visual experience, so her previous knowledge was incomplete.
4. There are truths that escape the physicalist story; physicalism is false.
5. Ability knowledge: the abilities to remember, imagine and recognise; knowing how, not knowing that.
6. Acquaintance with red: knowing it directly, not a new fact about it.
7. 'Water' and 'H_2O' are two concepts of one substance; Mary gains a new phenomenal concept of a physical fact she already knew.
8. If qualia are non-physical, yet physics explains all physical events, qualia must make no physical difference.

Arguments in order

Jackson's knowledge argument

1. Before her release, Mary knows all the physical facts about colour vision.
2. Before her release, Mary does not know everything about colour vision (she learns something on release).
3. So there are facts about colour vision that are not physical facts.
4. If physicalism is true, all facts are physical facts.
5. Therefore, physicalism is false.

The new knowledge/old fact response

1. One and the same fact can be known under two different concepts (water / H_2O).
2. Knowing a fact under one concept does not guarantee knowing it under the other.
3. On release, Mary acquires a phenomenal concept of seeing red.

4. This concept picks out a physical fact she already knew under a physical concept.
5. So Mary gains new knowledge, but not knowledge of a new fact.
6. Therefore, the knowledge argument does not show there are non-physical facts.

Objections: model responses

Objection	Possible response
Ability knowledge (Lewis)	Jackson: Mary also seems to gain a fact, e.g. '*this* is what others experienced'; abilities may not capture everything.
Acquaintance knowledge	Jackson: acquaintance with red seems to bring factual knowledge about what experience is like.
New knowledge / old fact (Tye)	Jackson: why can't the phenomenal concept be derived from the physical facts, if it is about the same fact?
Could Mary really know everything physical?	Jackson: the argument only needs the idea to be coherent; our intuition is still that she learns something.
Epiphenomenalism follows	This is a cost: epiphenomenalism faces the evolution and introspection objections. Jackson himself later rejected the argument.